Script for Guided Meditation

BASIC MINDFULNESS PRACTICE: BREATH AND BODY (7.5 MINUTES)

Finding a sitting position that allows you to be alert—spine erect but not stiff—and also relaxed. Closing your eyes and establishing a simple sense of presence. [Short pause.] Now, allowing your awareness to scan through your body and, wherever possible, softening and releasing obvious areas of physical tension.

[Long pause]

You might take a few very full breaths, and then allow your breath to be natural. [Short pause.] Bringing your attention to where you most easily detect the breath, or perhaps where it's most pleasurable … letting this place of experiencing the breath be your home base, an anchor to the present moment. Noticing this breath … right here.

[Short pause]

If the breath is not a good home base for you, you might instead anchor your attention in the sensations in your hands or the sensations of your whole body sitting here. [Short pause.]

Now, with a relaxed, interested attention, discovering what the sensations of the breath or your chosen anchor feel like, moment to moment.

[25 seconds]

Where is your attention now? Each time you notice that your mind has wandered off is a moment of mindfulness. Gently bringing your attention back to the inflow and outflow of the breath or your chosen anchor … offering a relaxed, wakeful presence.

[40 seconds]

Now, scanning your body and noticing if any particular sensations are strong, and calling your attention.

[Short pause]

If so, allowing the breath or your home base to recede to the background and bringing an interested, kind presence to the sensations.

[Short pause]

What do they feel like?

[Short pause]

You might be aware of heat or chills, tingling, aching, twisting, stabbing, vibrating … With a soft, open awareness, feeling the sensations as they are … noticing … are they pleasant or unpleasant? As you fully attend to them, do they become more intense or dissipate? Noticing how they change.

[Short pause]

When the sensations are no longer a strong experience, returning to mindfulness of breathing or your chosen anchor.

[1 minute]

If you find it difficult to stay with strong sensations, you might breathe with them, letting the breath help you find some balance and openness in the midst. It can also be helpful to name the sensations, seeing if there is a word that describes your experience: tightness, ache, heat, pressure … There is no need to strain or to run through a mental thesaurus to find the "right" word. Notice what word arises in awareness and mentally repeat it to yourself in a soft tone, letting the naming be soft in the background, five percent of your attention, with 95 percent on the actual experience.

[2.5 minutes]

You might ask yourself: *What is happening inside me right now?* Noticing any sensations that are predominant … and then ask: *Can I be with this?* Directly feeling the flow of sensation, subtle or strong, letting life be just as it is.

[1 minute]

Now, returning to your home base—the breath or anchor of particular sensations. Offering a calm, steady attention … If, during this last minute or so, strong sensations call your attention, letting your primary anchor recede, and bringing a full attention again to what's arising … naming what you notice, offering your presence. If nothing strong is calling your attention, continuing to rest with your home base … relaxed and alert.

[1.5 minutes]

Sensing the breath in the foreground, still aware of the field of sensations in the background. You are learning to be centered, balanced, and present for the breath and the living world of sensation … wisely aware of this changing life.